

as a poultice for skin diseases, sores, ulcers, and tumors. It was also given internally to relieve pain and to induce vomiting.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pokeweed is taken internally as a tincture in small amounts to treat rheumatic and arthritic conditions. The root has also been used to treat respiratory tract infections, such as sore throats and tonsillitis, as well as swollen glands and chronic infections. The herb is sometimes prescribed for pain and infection of the ovaries or testes, and as a lymphatic “decongestant,” stimulating the clearance of waste products. As a poultice or ointment, it is applied to sore and infected nipples and breasts, acne, folliculitis, fungal infections, and scabies.

⚠️ **Cautions** The plant is highly toxic in overdose. Use only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Picrasma excelsa syn. *Picraenia excelsa* (Simaroubaceae)

Quassia

Description Deciduous tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has smooth gray bark, compound leaves, small yellow flowers, and pea-sized black fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to tropical America and the Caribbean, quassia grows in forests and near water. It is cultivated mainly for medicinal use. The bark is harvested throughout the year.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Quassia contains quassinoid bitter principles (including quassin), alkaloids, a coumarin (scopoletin), and vitamin B₁. Some of the quassinoids have been shown to have cytotoxic (cell-killing) and anti-leukemic actions.

History & Folklore Quassia bark was first introduced into Europe from Surinam, then a Dutch colony, in 1756. The herb is named after Quassi, a native healer, who told Europeans of its therapeutic value.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The strongly bitter quassia supports and strengthens weak digestive systems. It increases bile flow and the secretion of salivary juices and stomach acid, and improves the digestive process as a whole. Quassia is commonly used to stimulate the appetite, especially in the treatment of anorexia. Its bitterness has led to it being used for malaria and other fevers, and it is given in the Caribbean for dysentery. The bark has been used in the form of an enema to expel threadworms and other parasites. A decoction of the bark may be used as an insect repellent and to treat headlice.

Cautions Excessive doses may, in some cases, cause digestive irritation and vomiting. Do not take during pregnancy.

Picrorrhiza kurroa (Scrophulariaceae)

Picrorrhiza

Description Hairy perennial with serrated elliptical leaves and white or lilac flowers growing in spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Picrorrhiza is native to the mountains of India, Nepal, and Tibet. The rhizome is gathered in autumn.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Picrorrhiza contains the bitter glycoside kutkin (composed of picrosides I to III and kutkoxide), iridoids, cucurbitacins, and apocynin. Apocynin is powerfully anti-inflammatory and reduces platelet aggregation.

History & Folklore Picrorrhiza has been used in Ayurvedic medicine as a laxative and bitter tonic since the earliest times.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In India, picrorrhiza is used as a bitter tonic, equivalent in many respects to gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99), and given for a wide range of digestive and liver troubles, such as indigestion, constipation, jaundice, and hepatitis. In China, it is chiefly employed to treat chronic diarrhea and dysentery. Picrorrhiza also helps treat asthma, acute and chronic infections, conditions where the immune system is compromised, and autoimmune diseases, including psoriasis and vitiligo. The herb's traditional use for liver disorders is well founded, and picrorrhiza may play an important role in treating liver disease.

Research In 1992 Indian trials, extracts of picrorrhiza were shown to boost immunity, and to have a specific action against *Leishmania donovani*, which causes the tropical parasitic disease known as leishmaniasis. Indian research also indicates that picrorrhiza is of therapeutic value in the treatment of autoimmune disease.

⚠️ **Caution** Take picrorrhiza only under professional supervision.

Pimenta officinalis (Myrtaceae)

Allspice

Description Aromatic evergreen tree growing to 39 ft (12 m). Has leathery oblong leaves, clusters of small white flowers, and tiny green berries that turn brown as they become ripe.

Habitat & Cultivation Allspice is native to the Caribbean and to Central and South America. The berries are gathered before they are fully ripe because the volatile oil content reduces as they mature.

Parts Used Berries, leaves, essential oil.

Constituents Allspice contains volatile oil (about 4%, mostly eugenol—up to 80%), lignins, and terpenoids.

History & Folklore Used as a spice in the Caribbean before the arrival of Europeans, allspice is now an ingredient in many well-known sauces, chutneys, and condiments.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A digestive stimulant, allspice is taken to relieve flatulence and indigestion. It may also be used to treat diarrhea. Allspice is often combined with herbs that have a tonic or laxative effect. The herb has an action that is similar to that of cloves (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97); both are stimulant, stomach-settling, and antiseptic. Allspice essential oil is markedly antiseptic and analgesic.

Research Taking a lead from allspice's use in Costa Rica as a menopause remedy, scientists found that the berries have a strong estrogenic activity. A 2009 paper suggested that allspice may well help with menopausal symptoms. Studies also indicate that allspice lowers high blood pressure.

Cautions Do not take essential oil internally without professional guidance. Do not take allspice as a medicine during pregnancy.

Pimpinella anisum (Apiaceae)

Anise

Description Erect annual growing to 2 ft (60 cm), with feathery leaves, umbels of yellow flowers, and ridged, gray-green seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Anise is native to the eastern Mediterranean, western Asia, and North Africa. It is widely cultivated for its seeds, which are used for medicinal purposes and as a flavoring in cooking.

Parts Used Seeds, essential oil.

Constituents Anise contains a volatile oil (comprising 70–90% anethole, together with methylchavicol and other terpenes), furanocoumarins, flavonoids, fatty acids, phenylpropanoids, sterols, and proteins. Anethole has an observed estrogenic effect, and the seeds as a whole are mildly estrogenic. This effect may substantiate the herb's use as a stimulant of sexual drive and of breast-milk production.

History & Folklore After examining the records of Cyprus hospital monastery, historians discovered that anise was used to treat plague and cholera during the Ottoman Period (1571–1878 CE).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Anise seeds are known for their ability to reduce gas and bloating, and to settle digestion. They are commonly given to infants and children to relieve colic, and to people of all ages to ease nausea and indigestion.